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Rose

The entire time Rose was in the café, her gaze switched between Léa sitting across from her and the door, with the possibility that André might appear. She worried he might not come—maybe he wouldn't get a day pass—but she kept looking for him, waiting, her leg moving up and down, knocking the table. And then, she saw him standing there—and her heart somersaulted. She stood, the blood rushing through her legs carrying her to him. He reached out and pulled her into his arms as if they were two lovers alone and not in a crowded café. He held her close and for the longest time neither spoke. They didn't need to. She could feel his heart pounding against her own. Twelve long months they'd been apart, but now she felt as though he'd never left her side.

"Welcome to Berlin," he said, pulling back and removing his hat. His black curls had been shorn and thin blue veins like tributaries were visible on his skull. "Let me get a good look at you." He smiled. "Just as beautiful as ever. How are you?"

"Good," she said, holding his hand as they'd done in the cinema a year ago. "It's lovely to see you again."

"It's wonderful to see you."

"Come, Léa's here too."

He followed Rose to the table. Léa stood.

"Why don't we all go outside?" André glanced over his shoulder, crushing his hat in his hand. Rose could see how thin and pale he'd become. His movements were no longer light and carefree but heavy like weights were tied to his limbs.

Outside, he put his hat on. The wind had quieted, but the sun struggled